

standoff, India not only withdrew its troops from offensive but also resumed diplomatic relations. The message to Pakistan: War was not an option for India. Islamabad's security establishment, especially the ISI, knew that it could carry out major strikes without India able to retaliate in manner that would seriously hurt Pakistan.

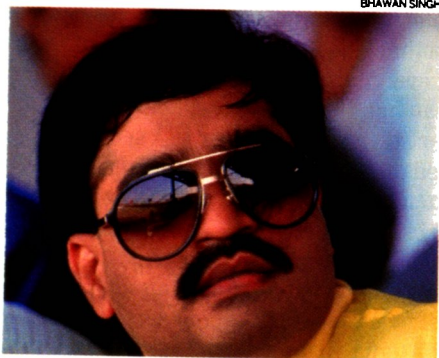
That knowledge has seen a rise in terrorist attacks in recent years with the Mumbai attacks an example of just how brazen it could get. The peace initiative in the past four years between the two countries had disturbed those who had profited from having relations remain hostile, especially elements in the Pakistan Army and the ISI. India meanwhile was projecting its growing power with not only striking a major nuclear deal with the US but poking in Pakistan's backyard by establishing strong ties with Hamid Karzai's Government in Afghanistan. With the Indian economy growing at an average of 7 per cent, Pakistan was feeling clearly outpaced. Meanwhile, with political insta-

late. India though can reverse that argument and use that to push the US and its allies to turn the heat on Pakistan. Also, the world is preoccupied with the financial crisis hitting the markets and doesn't want a messy blow-up in South Asia.

With internal political divisions considerably delaying the nuclear deal, India also lost the opportunity of having the US act against Pakistan when Bush was at the peak of his power. Nor did India work on building relations with Pakistan and settling outstanding disputes like Sir Creek and Siachen or even a long-term peace plan for Kashmir when President Pervez Musharraf was willing and his bargaining power was less.

With popular mood for it, India has also been exploring the military option. Part of the plan is to have surgical strikes on militant infrastructure in POK. But as General V.P. Malik, former army chief, says, "Such strikes are a risky gambit, as it can trigger a full scale war." With these camps constantly changing and Indian information about the movement of militant leaders suspect, the psychological gain from such a strike could evaporate if Pakistan began making retaliatory strikes. Retired Air Marshall Kapil Kak, co-director, Centre for Air Power Studies, cautions: "War is the last option we should exercise and its purpose must be absolutely clear. We should not fall into the trap that terrorists want us and blow up the whole peace process." Others like Brigadier Gurmeet Kanwal, director, Centre for Land Warfare Studies, feels "punitive action must be taken against them to send out a strong message". Among the measures he suggests is artillery firing to target Pakistan's vital installations and special forces raids against militant hideouts in POK. There is also the option of covert action. But ever since I.K. Gujral ordered its end when he was prime minister in the late 1990s, India has reportedly not exercised that option. There are other less risky ways of making Pakistan feel threatened. Experts say it's time India turns up the rhetoric on Baluchistan or separatist movements in Gilgit and put Pakistan on the defensive. As well as indicate that the military option is alive. Parthasarathy says, "The road to hell is usually paved with good intentions." India must act with clarity and judiciously in its efforts to rein in Pakistan.

BHAVAN SINGH



**US-DESIGNATED
GLOBAL TERROR-
IST DAWOOD
IBRAHIM LIVES IN
KARACHI; TERROR
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PAKISTAN**



bility and terror attacks, including the most recent at Islamabad's Marriott Hotel, saw Pakistan increasingly look like a failed state. The Mumbai attack was to show that despite its growing clout, India could be as vulnerable as Pakistan.

That the Mumbai attack was meticulously planned and perfectly timed to get maximum effect with minimum retaliation is evident. The calculations are that with Manmohan's Government almost a lame duck and Indian politics deeply divided, the chances of military counter-action by India were remote. With the Bush administration also winding down and the war in Afghanistan at a dangerous crossroads, the US would not want any destabilisation of the region and would press India not to threaten military retaliation. Pakistan has already indicated that it may have to move its one lakh troops stationed on the Afghan border to fight the Taliban and Al Qaeda to the Indian front if tensions esca-

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